

their almost undefended supply train. The Southern wagons and supplies were destroyed, and their horses and mules driven off.



Hostile environment

The Confederates underestimated the difficulty of campaigning across the wild, sparsely populated terrain of the southwestern territories, such as this mesa landscape near Santa Fe. The mountains and deserts made living off the land nearly impossible.

California retaliates

Unable to sustain an advance without supplies, Sibley pulled back first to Albuquerque and then began a grueling retreat to Texas in mid-April. By then another Union force was in play. Colonel James H. Carleton's California volunteers were marching eastward to intervene in the fighting in Arizona and New Mexico.

In March 1862, the Californians met the Confederates at Stanwix Station—a skirmish that impelled the much weaker Confederates to fall back to Tucson. The Californians then won a clash at Picacho Pass before driving the Rebels out of Tucson in May. They withdrew into Texas, and Carleton, now brigadier general, was put in charge of the Department of New Mexico. The Confederate Arizona Territory ceased to exist in all but name.